

A Contextual Reading of Justice In Ahmed Yerima's *Hard Ground* And Emenike Azunwo's *Wounded*

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Abstract

*Granted that some researchers have done enormous studies within the theme of justice in African dramaturgy, the specific critical problem such as how Nigerian drama, redefines justice beyond institutional legality into moral, emotional, and communal domains, have not received equal scholarly attention. This study therefore fills this gap by offering a contextual reading of justice in Ahmed Yerima's *Hard Ground* and Azunwo Emenike's *Wounded*, two Nigerian plays that interrogate violence, power, and the fragile search for justice within troubled socio-political landscapes. Drawing on the realities of conflict, militancy, and state failure, the study examines how both playwrights dramatize justice not as an abstract legal ideal, but as a lived, but contested experience shaped by history, culture, and human suffering. Anchored on Social Theory, the research adopts a qualitative and thematic approach to analyze how these playwrights represent justice as a contested idea within Nigeria's socio-political realities. Through close textual analysis, the article reveals how *Hard Ground* foregrounds cycle of violence and the tragic consequence of suppressed truth, while *Wounded* exposes the lingering psychological scars left by injustice and silence. By reading these plays within their socio-cultural contexts, the study clearly argues that African dramaturgy presents alternative justice narratives that challenge institutional inadequacies and privileges human experience, moral responsibility, and restorative possibilities. Ultimately, the article demonstrates that theatre functions as a critical space where suppressed voices are heard and justice is reimagined beyond the limits of formal legal systems. The article concludes that Yerima and Emenike use theatre not merely to represent injustice but to question who defines justice, who benefits from it, and whose 'wounds' remain unhealed.*

Key words: *Contextual Reading, Justice, African Dramaturgy, Nigerian Playwrights, Social Theory, Power.*

Introduction

Justice remains one of the most contested concepts in human society, often regarded as the foundation of peace, equity, and harmonious coexistence. In Africa, however, the pursuit of justice is frequently undermined by corruption, political manipulation, ethnic rivalries, and institutional inefficiencies. These conditions create a deep gap between the ideal of justice and the lived reality of the masses. The failure of legal and political systems to guarantee fairness has, over time, generated social disillusionment, civil unrest, and alternative forms of resistance. Consequently, public assessments of Nigeria's justice sector consistently register

concerns about bribery, case backlogs, and political interference (U.S. Department of State, 2024; Transparency International, 2025). In 2024/25, Nigeria scored 26/100 on the Corruption Perceptions Index and ranked 140/180, signaling persistent risks to fairness and accountability in the public sphere (Transparency International, 2025). While anti-corruption agencies report high-profile recoveries and convictions (Reuters, 2025), civil society and professional bodies continue to flag judicial vulnerability to influence and the erosion of public trust (Chatham House, 2024; Nigerian Bar Association, 2025).

Just few months ago, September 10th, 2025, Chatham House through *Business Day Nig.* reported that “Police, Presidency, among Nigeria's most distrusted institutions”. In this report, Ogunjuyibe writes that Nigerians have reportedly lost confidence in their most important institutions, with the police, the presidency [also the Judiciary,] and the federal government ranking among the least trusted, according to a new national survey conducted by Chatham House in partnership with the National Bureau of Statistics. This survey according to him was part of Chatham House Social Norms and Accountability Governance project which examines how trust affects governance across different countries. The survey clearly indicates that all respondents – 46% said they “greatly distrust” the police, making the most distrusted institution. Only 7% expressed strong trust in the police.

The presidency and the federal government fared little better. Some 36% of people said they greatly distrusted the presidency, while 35% felt the same way about the federal government. This same survey equally indicates that the courts, local councils and state-level politicians also received poor ratings from the public. Conclusively, the findings suggest that 25 years of attempts to tackle corruption have not worked. The report argues that these efforts have failed to create stronger accountability. Instead, political campaigns focused on party loyalty, unpunished wrongdoing, and unequal law enforcement have damaged the reputation of public institutions. Within this landscape fraught with fragile institutions of public interest, literature, and drama in particular, have served as a viable space where such abnormalities are interrogated. Nigerian dramatists have persistently engaged with questions of justice, exposing its absence in the socio-political order and projecting possibilities for reform. The two texts at the center of this study; Ahmed Yerima's *Hard Ground*, and Emenike Azunwo's *Wounded*, offer deeper insights on the perspectives of justice and factors that impede its implementation in Nigeria such as the collapse of state protection as seen in Yerima's *Hard Ground*, and trauma and the silencing of victims in Emenike's *Wounded*.

Generally, studies in the field of African drama have continued to reveal a common theme about its justice system, reflecting the continent's complex history, cultural diversity, and ongoing struggles for equality and human rights (Mugo, 2015 & Osofisan, 2007). African playwrights have consistently used their works as a platform to critique the justice system, challenge societal norms, and advocate for reforms (Ngugi wa Thiong'o, 1986; Fugard, 1973 & Osofisan, 1982). Achebe, one of the Nigeria's foremost historians and a literary scholar, reflects in his *Things Fall Apart* (1958) that from the colonial era to the present day, the justice system in Africa has been shaped by a complex interplay of traditional, colonial, and post-colonial influences. This according to Soyinka, another literary giant from Africa, has resulted in a system that often prioritizes punishment over rehabilitation, and perpetuates inequality and discrimination (Soyinka, 1976).

Consequently, African dramatists have responded to these injustices through their works, offering criticism on this kind of justice system and its impact on individuals and communities.

Just like the male theatre practitioners cited above, African female playwrights have also used their works to criticize the justice system, especially as it affects them. Therefore, justice for gender inequality, is another crucial theme in African drama. In this regard, Ama Ata Aidoo's *Anowa* (1970) criticizes the patriarchal norms that limit women's autonomy and subject them to unjust treatment under both customary and colonial legal structures. Similarly, Zulu Sofola's *Wedlock of the Gods* (1972), challenges traditional marriage laws that undermine women's rights, portraying a justice system that prioritizes cultural customs over individual freedoms. Consequently, Boyce Davies emphasizes that African female playwrights often reimagine justice in ways that empower female characters, advocating for more inclusive legal and social reforms (1994).

However, while all the above male and female writers can be said to have belonged to the classical era, Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie is currently the most vibrant contemporary female writer championing the course of justice for the female gender in Nigeria, and even in Africa, through her works such as *The Purple Hibiscus* (2003), *Half of a Yellow Sun* (2006), *Americana* (2013), including her latest novel; *Dream Count* (2025) which she unveiled in the US on the 26th of February, 2025. From these few reviews above, it's clear that the context of justice is a perennial theme in African plays in general, and in Nigerian plays in particular.

Synopsis of Ahmed Yerima's *Hard Ground*

Ahmed Yerima's *Hard Ground* explores the Niger Delta crisis through the intimate conflict of a family, using the home as a symbol of the Nigerian nation. The play centers on Mama, a grieving mother, and her son Nimi, who joins militant youths protesting government neglect, corruption, and environmental degradation caused by oil exploitation. Mama represents the older generation yearning for peace, while Nimi embodies the anger and frustration of abandoned youths who see violence as their only path to justice. The title reflects both the polluted land and the hardened emotional state of the people. Ultimately, the play presents justice as a moral and political failure, showing that militancy deepens suffering rather than resolving it. This masterpiece gives a voice to the ordinary people caught between corrupt leaders and desperate rebels. *Hard Ground* is not just about militancy in the Niger Delta region, nationally, it is about what happens when a society fails its people, and about the quiet endurance of those who still dream of a better Nigeria even when everything around them has fallen apart, and the center can no longer hold, as Achebe once cried out.

Analysis of the Context of Justice in Ahmed Yerima's *Hard Ground*

Ahmed Yerima's *Hard Ground* (2006) emerged at a critical moment in Nigeria's history, when the Niger Delta crisis had become both a national headline and a lived reality for thousands of people in the South-South region of Nigeria. First staged in 2006 and winning the NLNG Prize for Literature that same year, the play situates its drama not in the oil fields or the corridors of power, but within the intimate domestic space of a Delta household (The Nigeria Prizes, 2006). This deliberate choice shifts the audience's attention from spectacle to human consequence. Through this play, Yerima explores how injustice, corruption, and failed governance can lead to rebellion, loss, and the collapse of communal order in our society.

Primarily, *Hard Ground* dramatizes the moral and environmental collapse of the Niger Delta region under the weight of political corruption, poverty, and the frustrated anger of its youth. The play situates justice not merely as a legal institution but as a moral question - one that the nation has failed to properly address till date. Yerima's use of the family unit in the play as a symbol of the larger Nigerian society, makes the story intimate yet politically and nationally relevant. The central conflict between Mama and her son, Nimi, mirrors the broken dialogue between the Nigerian state and the people of Niger Delta.

From the play's opening dialogues, Yerima allows the reader to sense a country where justice has become a thing of luxury among the elite class. Nimi, who joins a militant group, justifies his violent acts as a necessary rebellion against a corrupt and indifferent government in collaboration with multinational companies. His words to Mama; "They left us nothing but anger. We must fight back or die doing nothing", reveal a distorted sense of justice, born out of neglect and disillusionment. This line encapsulates what this study considers the tragic irony of justice which in my perspective is a justice that seeks redemption through imminent destruction. Mama's character, on the other hand, represents the fate of the older generation in a world that has transformed beyond the one they knew. Her pleas for peace and forgiveness contrast sharply with Nimi's fiery vengeance. Yet, her silence and helplessness also reveal complicity, the passive acceptance of injustice that has allowed corruption to fester. In this sense, Yerima does not present justice as a simple act of right and wrong, but as a layered moral dimension where everyone bears guilt. This study however, interprets Mama's grief not just as maternal pain but as symbolic of Nigeria's collective sorrow, a society mourning the loss of fairness and truth.

In this play, one can argue that Yerima's dramatic technique also reinforces his personal idea of justice. The confined setting of the family home becomes a courtroom where every conversation turns into a moral judgment. This study further contends that *Hard Ground* situates justice as a burden carried by ordinary people rather than institutions. In the absence of state intervention, moral responsibility shifts to individuals such as mothers, sons, and neighbours who as seen in the play, must redefine what it means to be just. The play therefore transforms the concept of justice from a legal abstraction into a lived, painful reality. In doing so, Yerima crafts a form of theatre that not only reflects social crisis but interrogates the nation's conscience. Also, what makes Yerima's vision of justice compelling is that it grows out of socio-political realism in the Niger Delta region, not idealism. He does not offer solutions instead; he mirrors the contradictions of a society where the oppressed have learned the language of their oppressors. The militants demand justice through violence, while the state enforces peace through oppression. Both sides becoming reflections of each other's cruelty and disillusionment. This duality aligns with Yerima's long-standing concern with the cyclical nature of injustice in Nigerian politics, a theme evident across his other works.

Each character in the drama, embodies a perspective on justice and survival. Nimi, a young militant, represents the frustrated youths of the Niger Delta region who are driven by poverty and systemic neglect, resort to arms in the fight for justice. On the other hand, Mama, his mother, embodies the old moral conscience of society, one that longs for peace, dialogue, and traditional order; Baba, a hesitant elder whose indecision exposes the limitations of moral authority; Don, a militant leader who embodies both the legitimate grievances and the

potentially corrupting allure of power; Pikibo, who mediates and witnesses the family's moral crises. Her fate is a tragic one, and her death and that of her child, serve as a poignant reminder of the devastating consequences of violence and conflict, especially on women and children in the Niger Delta region. There are also additional figures like Alabo and Tingolongo, whose roles expand the relational and generational dimensions of the drama. Together, these characters form a compact, intense world in which justice is continually made, challenged, and undone by small acts, words, and choices. Through them, Yerima dramatizes how the struggle for justice becomes distorted by vengeance and bloodshed.

One cannot read *Hard Ground* without recognizing the significance of material dispossession. The Niger Delta's oil wealth fuels the national economy, yet the communities living on this land remain deprived of infrastructure, clean water, and sustainable livelihoods. Mark (2019) succinctly argues that in the case Niger Delta insurgence, one can say that their fight is for resource control. Consequently, scholars like Lawal (2020) and Nwagbara (2010) stress that Yerima's characters are products of this structural neglect. Based on these submissions, this study therefore concludes that Nimi's turn to militancy, for example, is not a personal choice but a socially conditioned response: when the land is poisoned, rivers polluted, and traditional avenues for redress fail, violence becomes the only way to reclaim justice. Through *Hard Ground* Yerima stages an intricate, intimate, and politically urgent argument about justice. He transforms national issues of oil, governance, and systemic neglect into the texture of family life, where grief, anger, and moral decision-making collide. The play exposes injustice as resource theft, environmental degradation, leadership failure, and social silence. In a country struggling to convert wealth into wellbeing, Yerima's drama compels a reimagining of justice: inclusive, ecologically conscious, and socially restorative.

Synopsis of Emenike Azunwo's *Wounded*

Emenike's *Wounded* is a domestic drama that explores love, ambition, and emotional power. It follows Femi and Lucia, a couple from Nigeria whose hopeful love deteriorates over time. Their relationship while in Nigeria begins with mutual support and shared dreams and upon Migration to the UK, it also symbolizes hope and a better future. Femi sacrifices to support Lucia's nursing career. But as Lucia succeeds, the balance of power shifts. Her financial independence and newly found freedom, breeds pride and resentment. Love gradually turns into emotional cruelty and control. Lucia belittles Femi, undermining his dignity and identity. Femi becomes emotionally wounded and psychologically trapped. Once affectionate, he descends into despair and isolation. He realizes the woman he supported has become his oppressor. The play reaches a tragic and irreversible climax. *Wounded* exposes the silent suffering of men in abusive relationships. Precisely, Emenike warns that love without respect becomes destructive and deadly.

Analysis of the Context of Justice in Emenike Azunwo's *Wounded*

Justice, in its truest form, is not only the question of law but the pursuit of fairness, moral balance, and the restoration of human dignity. In *Wounded* (2024), this moral pursuit takes on an intimate and unsettling shape. The play's artistic world is not a courtroom, nor a battlefield, nor even the public square; it is the marriage between Femi and Lucia, a union that begins as love's promise but dissolves into a theatre of emotional cruelty and personal destruction. The story does not announce itself as a political or social allegory, yet at its heart lies a deep meditation on

the question of “justice” - what it means to be seen, heard, respected, and treated fairly within the intimate space of love.

At first, Femi and Lucia's story appears to be one of shared dreams. Their marriage, born from youthful affection and optimism, carries the tender expectations of two people determined to build a future together. Femi, the loving husband, envisions a life where partnership thrives through sacrifice. Lucia, driven by ambition and feminist ideologies, represents the modern woman eager to break free from dependence and patriarchy. When they relocate to the United Kingdom, Femi does so out of love and conviction that he wants Lucia to succeed, to achieve the nursing career she dreams of. His gesture is an act of justice in its own right because he gives her the right to growth, the freedom to rise. He sees her as an equal and a companion, not a possession. In this early phase, justice exists in balance, in the harmony of mutual respect and shared purpose.

However, justice in *Wounded* begins to fracture when success becomes power, and power loses compassion. Lucia's growth as a professional nurse marks a turning point, not because her ambition is wrong, but because it begins to redefine her sense of worth and her perception of her husband. Her economic empowerment slowly transits into a moral weapon consequently, the subtle inequalities of gender, culture, and ego erupt within their household. What begins as confidence, transforms into control. Lucia, now earning more and commanding social authority, becomes emotionally distant, contemptuous, and verbally abusive. Her cruelty does not manifest through physical violence but through words that 'wound' deeper than flesh. In this transformation, the playwright questions the very nature of justice in human relationships. In his modest imagination, Emenike perhaps asks; can success ever justify the denial of another's humanity?

The tragedy of *Wounded* unfolds not in sudden violence but in gradual erosion. Love turns into pity, pity into resentment, resentment into emotional warfare. The home that once promised comfort becomes a courtroom without judge or mercy. Femi, desperate to restore his lost dignity, wrestles between endurance and rebellion. His silence becomes a prison; his patience, a slow death. Justice, in his world, is no longer an abstract concept but the right to be treated as human. When he finally breaks, when despair drives him toward a dark and irreversible decision, it is not rage that propels him but the exhaustion of being unheard. His resolve to murder Lucia, however tragic, becomes a desperate cry for recognition, an attempt to restore a moral order that love had shattered. In this light, Emenike redefines justice as something deeply personal. It is not the verdict of courts but the equilibrium of hearts. It exists when two people see each other as equals, respect each other's dignity, and share power without domination. Femi's tragedy lies in his inability to defend this equilibrium once it begins to crumble. Lucia's tragedy lies in mistaking dominance for independence. Both are victims of the imbalance they create, and their fall becomes an indictment of a world where emotional justice remains unspoken.

The migration, also known as the *japa* backdrop of the story, further complicates the theme. In moving to the UK, Femi and Lucia cross not only physical borders but also moral borders. The promise of a “better life” exposes them to a different cultural space, one that often alienates African immigrants from their roots and from each other. Femi's sense of masculinity, formed in a traditional African context is hereby tested in a foreign land where gender dynamics

and social expectations differ sharply. Lucia's exposure to Western ideals of feminism and individualism empower her but also detach her from the communal values that once bound their relationship. Thus, *Wounded* transforms into a psychological landscape of disorientation. Here, justice therefore is not only emotional but cultural, the struggle to find balance between love and liberation, tradition and modernity, dependence and freedom.

As the story reaches its dark conclusion, tragedy becomes a form of poetic justice. Femi's fateful act of violence and self-destruction, force the audience to face the costs of emotional neglect. Lucia, left to confront the ruins of her choices, embodies the bitter lesson that victory built on humiliation is defeat in disguise. Her success, stripped of love and mutual respect, turns hollow. Justice returns, not through Femi's imminent punishment, but through realization, the painful awareness of what true love required but she failed to give. The emotional realism of *Wounded* is what makes its exploration of justice deeply human. The playwright does not seek heroes or villains. He seeks understanding. Both characters are flawed, both yearning for dignity, both trapped in their wounds. Femi's silence and Lucia's arrogance are two sides of the same coin - the human fear of powerlessness. Justice, the playwright suggests, cannot exist where fear reigns. Only love rooted in humility can restore balance. The moral theme of *Wounded* is, therefore, not punitive but redemptive, meaning that justice emerges not from revenge but from recognition, that is, recognizing the humanity in the other, even in pain.

Seen in that perspective, *Wounded* transcends the boundaries of domestic drama. It becomes a moral allegory about power and tenderness, pride and forgiveness. Its major focus on the marital relationship between Femi and Lucia, reflects the intimacy of its ethical argument that justice begins at home, that is, in how we treat those closest to us. Emenike insists that emotional cruelty, though invisible, is as destructive as physical violence. He challenges us to reconsider the moral economy of relationships, to see justice not as something demanded from court rooms, but as something lived between hearts. For instance, if one reads deeper, Femi's endurance can be seen as a moral protest, a quiet rebellion against the injustice of humiliation. His suffering bears the nobility of restraint; his eventual collapse, the cost of a justice denied too long. On the other hand, Lucia's triumph is a hollow victory that teaches the futility of power without compassion. The moral ethos of the play thus, turns circular, injustice breeds tragedy, and tragedy becomes the soil from which moral awareness grows. By the end, the audience is left not with judgment but reflection on how easily love can turn oppressive when power is unchecked.

Justice, in *Wounded*, is ultimately portrayed as a moral dialogue between two souls. It is the fragile space between giving and taking, speaking and listening, loving and hurting. It is the thread that holds relationships together and once broken, even love cannot survive. The playwright's brilliance lies in showing that justice is not a system but a feeling, a moral temperature that determines whether love heals or destroys and in the end, Femi's tragedy is not only personal, it is universal. He stands for every person whose kindness is mistaken for weakness, whose loyalty becomes a cage, whose love becomes his undoing consequently, Femi cries out "My deeds have become pain..." His story forces us to ask: What justice exists for those who suffer silently? What redemption is possible when love turns cruel? *Wounded* does not answer these questions directly; it lets them linger, like an ache that refuses to fade. In doing so, the playwright fulfills its title's promise, leaving us all a little wounded, a little wiser, but

more aware of the delicate justice that love demands.

Comparative Analysis of the Context of Justice in *Hard Ground* and *Wounded*

Justice in Nigerian drama as earlier stated, often emerges not as an abstract legal principle but as a lived condition shaped by pain, power, silence, and survival. Both Ahmed Yerima's *Hard Ground* and Emenike Azunwo's *Wounded* engage deeply with this lived reality, yet they approach justice from different social locations and emotional terrains. For instance, while *Hard Ground* situates justice within the violent political struggle of the Niger Delta, *Wounded* shifts the question of justice into the intimate domestic space of marriage, migration, and emotional abuse. Analyzed together, the two plays reveal how injustice operates across public and private spheres, exposing the fragile boundaries between law, morality, and human dignity.

In *Hard Ground*, justice is framed by Yerima against a backdrop of national betrayal. The Niger Delta setting is not incidental; it is the moral engine of the play. Oil wealth flows outward, while suffering remains local. Characters such as Nimi, Mama, Don, Baba, Pikibo, and Alabo are not merely individuals but 'social conditions' shaped by prolonged environmental and socio-political neglect in that region. From Yerima's perspective, justice in Niger Delta is born out of absence; absence of state protection, economic fairness, and of meaningful dialogue with the elite class. Consequently, justice becomes reimagined as 'retaliation'. Therefore, militancy, sabotage, and violence are presented not as innate criminal impulses by Yerima, but as desperate responses to systemic exclusion and negligence. Yerima does not romanticize this concept of violence instead, he exposes its tragic cost. For instance, Nimi's involvement in militancy is driven by a belief that force is the only language the state understands. Yet the play constantly questions whether this belief truly restores justice or simply reproduces another cycle of suffering. Mama's presence is crucial in this moral tension. She stands as the emotional and ethical conscience of the play, repeatedly asking whether bloodshed can ever heal injustice. Through her grief and resistance, Yerima suggests that justice divorced from humanity becomes indistinguishable from cruelty.

By contrast, *Wounded* removes justice from the terrain of oil politics and places it within the emotional platform of marriage and migration. Here, the injustice is less obvious but not less devastating. Reading the text, one understands that Femi's suffering does not stem from state violence or environmental exploitation as seen in *Hard Ground*, but from emotional domination and psychological erosion within an intimate relationship. Lucia's rise in career and social status, initially appears as a success story, especially within the migrant narrative of unlimited success. However, as the power balance in the marriage shifts, justice becomes distorted within the home.

Unlike in *Hard Ground*, where injustice is collective and visible, *Wounded* deals with injustice that is private, hidden, unsuspecting and oftentimes dismissed. Emotional in this case, abuse lacks the dramatic spectacle of armed struggle yet, its impact is equally destructive. Femi's dignity is gradually stripped away through ridicule, control, and humiliation from his spouse. The justice system in *Wounded* is therefore notable for its silence. There is no court intervention, no community mediation, and no effective social safety plan. Here, Emenike subtly contends that justice fails not because it is actively denied but because it is structurally absent from intimate spaces.

This contrast highlights a key difference in how both playwrights conceptualize justice. In *Hard Ground*, justice is loudly contested in public spaces through confrontation and resistance. In *Wounded*, it is quietly eroded behind closed doors. Yet, both plays converge on a shared truth that when justice is inaccessible, individuals are pushed toward destructive choices. Hence, Nimi turns to militancy; Femi turns toward a decision that ultimately leads to tragedy. In both cases, injustice does not merely harm, it reshapes identity. Another crucial point of comparison in the two plays lies in how power functions within each play. In *Hard Ground*, power is externalized. It belongs to the state, multinational corporations, and political elites who remain largely invisible yet very powerful. The characters' struggle for justice is therefore upward and downward. But, in *Wounded*, power is internalized within the marital relationship. Lucia's economic and social advancement grants her emotional leverage, which she uses consciously or unconsciously, to dominate Femi. Justice, in this context, becomes entangled with gender expectations, masculinity, and economic dependency. Importantly, *Wounded* resists simplistic moral binaries. Lucia is not portrayed as evil in a conventional sense, rather, she becomes a product of a system that equates success with control. Her behavior reflects how power, once acquired, can replicate oppressive structures (as attested to by the French Philosopher Baron de Montesquieu who famously argued that "power corrupts, and absolute power corrupts absolutely") even within relationships founded on love. This mirrors *Hard Ground*, where former victims of injustice risk becoming perpetrators themselves. Both plays therefore complicate the idea of justice as something one simply "achieves." Instead, justice is shown as fragile, easily corrupted by power.

The tragic endings of both plays further deepen this comparison. In *Hard Ground*, death underscores the futility of violent justice. The hard ground becomes a metaphor for moral barrenness, a space where hope struggles to grow. In *Wounded*, tragedy emerges from emotional exhaustion and loss of selfhood. Femi's final choice is not an assertion of justice but a cry born from its absence. These endings do not offer resolution; they offer warning. Justice delayed, distorted, or denied does not disappear, it mutates into irreversible damage. However, what is particularly striking is how both playwrights position the audience as moral witnesses. Yerima confronts the audience with uncomfortable questions about national complicity. Silence, apathy, and benefit from exploitation are all forms of injustice from Yerima's perspective. Emenike, on the other hand, challenges his audiences to reconsider what abuse looks like and who qualifies as a victim. By centering on a male character's emotional suffering, *Wounded* disrupts assumptions about gender, power, and justice, insisting that injustice does not always follow expected patterns.

Ultimately, *Hard Ground* and *Wounded* reveal that justice in Nigerian dramaturgy is not confined to courtrooms or constitutions. It exists in homes, relationships, communities, and unspoken decisions. One playwright speaks through the noise of guns and protests; the other speaks through silence and emotional collapse. Yet both insist that justice is inseparable from dignity. Where dignity is denied, whether by the state or by a loved one, justice becomes a contested, painful, and often tragic pursuit. Read comparatively, the two plays expand the scope of justice discourse in Nigerian drama. They demonstrate that justice must be understood not only as a legal or political issue but as a deeply human concern shaped by power relations, emotional vulnerability, and social neglect. In doing so, Yerima and Emenike remind us that

injustice does not always announce itself loudly. Sometimes, it grows quietly, wounds deeply, and destroys completely.

Summary

This study has successfully established that the four selected plays are united by their concern with justice, both social and moral as a central theme. Each playwright employs unique dramatic forms to question systems of power, reveal patterns of injustice and oppression, and advocate for fairness. In *Hard Ground*, Yerima portrays the Niger Delta as a space torn between militant struggles and failed governance. The quest for justice becomes a generational burden, with Nimi's disillusionment and Mama's anguish capturing the loss of faith in social institutions. The play exposes how state neglect and youth frustration transform justice into a cycle of revenge and despair. In *Wounded*, Emenike shifts justice into the private space, dramatizing emotional and gendered forms of injustice. Through Femi's victimization, the play interrogates how love, ambition, and inequality can transform into instruments of control and humiliation. Justice in this context becomes psychological healing and self-redemption, a cry for balance in human relationships. Through these plays, the study found that Nigerian dramatists employ dialogue, symbolism, and character conflicts not merely to entertain but to compel social conscience to confront injustice, moral reflection, and empathy.

Conclusion

From the findings, it becomes clear that theatre in Nigerian continues to serve as a vital instrument of social commentary. Each playwright under this study redefines justice in ways that are deeply rooted in the Nigerian experience. For instance, Yerima's justice is communal and political while Emenike's exposition is personal and emotional. The study concludes that these dramatic representations of justice reflect the nation's evolving consciousness where political greed, moral compromise, and social inequality threaten the ideals of justice and human dignity. The plays collectively suggest that justice cannot exist in isolation from truth, compassion, and accountability. Whether through satire, tragedy, or psychological realism, these dramatists insist that art must confront power and conscience. Justice, in their vision, is not a distant dream but a demand; a moral necessity that sustains both individual and communal existence, rooted in empathy, respect, and collective wellbeing.

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